

thrashed. The CX-8300 is faster in all tests and it even clocks better test scores than the more expensive Canon devices. This despite the fact that the Epson devices are equipped with just 64 KB of input buffer memory. Canon devices logged scores that are neither too bad nor exceptional, but when we look at the print quality, the time required is easily justified. In the photo printout test, Epson's RX610 takes the pole and does the job in just 83 seconds; excellent. Both Canon's take around 120 seconds to do the same but return better quality than the Epson. Brother MFC-235C and Epson CX8300 take unusually long time to print the photo.

In the scanner speed test, Both Canon devices complete the 150 dpi photograph scan in just 10 seconds, while the Epson RX610 takes just 2 seconds more. The Epson CX8300 takes more time, but delivers exceptional scan quality. Brother's MFC-235C delivers the goods in the 600 dpi test. In the copy speed test, Brother's MFC-235C and Epson's CX-8300 make it to the top with identical timings. Epson does slightly better by offering marginally better copy quality. Both Canon printers lag the rest in the copy speed test by a substantial margin.

When it comes to print quality, we have high expectations from Canon, and the MP476 doesn't disappoint. Be it colour saturation, detail or sharpness, Canon delivers on all accounts. Only in the photograph did the Canon lose to the Epson RX-610's brilliant output; albeit by a small margin. The photograph from the Canon printer had a hint of yellow, which was missing in the Epson RX-610's output. The Canon MX-308 also delivers good printing quality but a shade below the MP476 and the RX-610.

In the scan quality test, the Epson CX-8300 does an excellent job and trumps both Epson's RX-610 and Canon's MP476. It beats all other devices in all aspects and reproduces images faithfully. The RX-610 comes in at second

place here, followed closely by Canon; Brother stands last. In the copy quality, Canon takes the lead thanks to it's superb printing engine.

Epson's Stylus RX-610 comes out as the clear winner when we add up the performance and features score, but the CX-8300 offers better value at a lower price and wins our *Best Buy* award in this category. If you want a photo quality printer though, then the RX-610 makes more sense. Both Canons impress with their features and performance, but are priced too high.

High-end MFDs

These products offer the best in terms of features and performance that the well-moneyed look for in an MFD.

Features

Brother's MFC-685CW takes the honour for being the best designed MFD. Aesthetically, it's one of the best MFDs we have seen so far. Don't get fooled by its small demeanour—it packs a punch. To begin with, this is the only device to offer Wireless networking out of the box and it supports 802.11b / g devices. It also supports 10 / 100 Ethernet. It features a memory card reader, PictBridge, an ADF, fax (with a hand receiver) and an LCD screen. This entire package is available for not more than Rs 14,000, things can't get better than this!

While the MFC-685CW is clearly a consumer product, the other two devices—the MFC-5460 and MFC-5860CN—are oriented towards office users. Both these devices are near-identical. However, the MFC-5860CN is upmarket and has one additional feature—an extra paper tray that can hold another 250 pages. Despite being targeted at

office users, both these devices offer memory card readers and PictBridge compliance. They support advanced fax features and can store up to 400 pages in the 32 MB of inbuilt memory. Unlike the MFC-685CW, both these devices don't offer hand receivers. Both devices also have 35-page ADFs. However, neither supports automatic duplex printing and that's a definite shortcoming considering that they are office devices. Setting them up on a network is quite simple—you only need to know some basic networking.

Canon's PIXMA MP610 looks appealing. Although boxy, it cleverly hides some nifty features. First, the LCD folds down and hides the operating console. The menu navigation is accomplished using a jog wheel which is intuitive to use. The memory card reader is also hidden behind a small door in the front, with only the PictBridge port visible. This is the only devices to have two paper feeding mechanisms with a selector switch on the operating console. Being consumer oriented it lacks fax capability, but makes up for it via its photo printing features. Importantly, it is the only device in this entire comparison to offer duplex printing, thus saving on paper in the longer run. Though the device lacks any network support it does offer USB and IrDA (infrared) with Bluetooth being optional. The MP610 can also print on CDs and DVDs directly and the software suite offered is pretty much similar in functionality as the Canon MP476.

Epson's Stylus RX-690 also offers features similar to Canon's MP610 and is designed along the same lines. The RX-690 is bulky and requires lots of desk space—however, the design is appealing thanks to the glossy black mate-

rial used. The Epson RX-690 lacks fax capabilities but offers advance scanning and copying features. USB is the only interface offered on this device.

Performance

In terms of printing speed, Canon's MP610 takes top spot. It can deliver the first print in just nine seconds. Only in the photograph printout test did it lose to Epson RX-690 by 11 seconds.

Epson's RX690 performs well in the print speed tests, but is behind the Canon MP610 in all tests except the photograph printout. The Epson RX690 betters Brother MFDs by a huge margin, clearly demonstrating its superior printing engine.

All three Brother devices have a slow print engine and hence take slightly longer to print similar documents. Their performance in the photograph printing test is abysmal in contrast to Canon MP610 and Epson RX690.

In the scan speed test, Canon MP610 took the least amount of time and posted the best scores across all categories. It took just five seconds to scan an A4 size photograph at 150 dpi. Epson's RX-690 takes slightly longer than the Canon MP610 but is reasonably fast. The Brother MFC-685CW and MFC-5460CN post similar results and are faster than the more expensive MFC-5860CN. The MFC-685CW posts the second-best score after the Canon MP610 in the 600 dpi, full photograph scan test. Similar results can be seen in the copying speed test too, where it takes second spot ahead of Epson's RX690, but is defeated by Canon's MP610.

Coming to print quality, Canon takes the crown with impeccable printing quality. Colour saturation near-perfect and photographs come out superb. What's really amazing about the MP610 is that it is able to reproduce stunning quality without curtailing printing speed. We expected the Epson RX690 to do better, however the print quality is just not in Canon's class. Brother MFC-685CW, MFC-5460CN and 5860CN delivered reasonably good printouts. Canon tops the copy quality test too, thanks to its excellent print engine. All other devices are on par with each other in this regard.

Epson's RX690 makes up for its shortcomings by delivering exceptional scanned images. Colour saturation, tonal neutrality, details and sharpness all were well within check and the final image was stunning. The Canon MP610 did deliver reasonably good results but was outclassed by Epson's RX690. Brother's scanning unit in all three devices goes overboard with image sharpening and loses out on detail, but delivers decent colour saturation.

Canon's MP-610 is the clear winner here, posting the best scores in speed test and delivering exceptional quality. Though priced on the higher side, its terrific performance makes up for that and hence we give it our Best Buy and Performance award. Brother's 685CW probably offers the best features but gets overshadowed by Canon's sterling performance. ■

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